

Ancient Rome

The Roman Republic was established c.500 BCE, and the subsequent empire eventually stretched to Greece, western Europe, north Africa and parts of the Middle East. As a result, Roman art was an amalgam of styles from many cultures, particularly Greece. Much of it was created as propaganda – portrait busts were tributes to powerful figures. They were intended to look true to life, and included wrinkles, receding hairlines and sagging jowls. To commemorate victories, generals built triumphal arches and monuments. One of the best known is Trajan's Column in Rome, a spiralling monumental relief depicting the conquest of the Dacia in 101–106 CE.

Murals painted in the homes of the wealthy depicted naturalistic scenes of daily life. Artists intuitively expressed linear and aerial perspective to create illusions of three-dimensionality. They also produced wall and floor mosaics that were often realistic and portrayed movement, tonal contrast and expression. Monumental architecture was also embellished with statues and lively reliefs.



Bust of Augustus, first century CE